

grandfather, the grocery store owner, gave Howard money to help support his family.

Fortunately, the sense of hopelessness did not last long. Howard Buffett soon pulled himself up and got back on his feet, announcing that Buffett, Sklenicka & Company had opened for business at the Union State building on Farnam Street, the same street where Buffett would someday buy a house and start his investment partnership.

The effect of the Great Depression, albeit brief, was hard on Buffett's family. It also made a deep and profound impression on young Warren. "He emerged from those first hard years with an absolute drive to become very, very, very rich," wrote Roger Lowenstein, author of *Buffett: The Making of an American Capitalist*. "He thought about it before he was five years old. And from that time on, he scarcely stopped thinking about it."⁹

When Buffett turned 10, his father took him to New York. It was a birthday gift Howard gave to each of his children. "I told my Dad I wanted to see three things," said Buffett. "I wanted to see the Scott Stamp and Coin Company. I wanted to see the Lionel Train Company. I wanted to see the New York Stock Exchange."¹⁰ After an overnight ride on the train, Buffett and his dad made their way to Wall Street, where they met with At Mol, a member of the exchange. "After lunch, a guy came along with a tray that had all these different kinds of tobacco leaves on it," recalled Buffett. "He made up a cigar for Mr. Mol, who picked out the leaves he wanted. And I thought, this is it. It doesn't get any better than this. A custom-made cigar."¹¹

Later, Howard Buffett introduced his son to Sidney Weinberg, a senior partner at Goldman Sachs, then considered the most famous man on Wall Street. Standing in Weinberg's office, Buffett was mesmerized by the photographs and documents on the wall. He took note of the framed original letters, knowing full well they were written by famous people. While Howard and Sidney talked about financial issues of the day, Buffett was oblivious, walking around and around Weinberg's office staring at the artifacts. When it was time to go, Sidney Weinberg put his arm around Buffett and jokingly asked him what stock he liked. "He'd forgotten it all the next day," Buffett recalled, "but I remembered it forever."¹²

Even before Buffett traveled to New York, he was already intrigued with stocks and the stock market. He was a frequent visitor to his dad's